

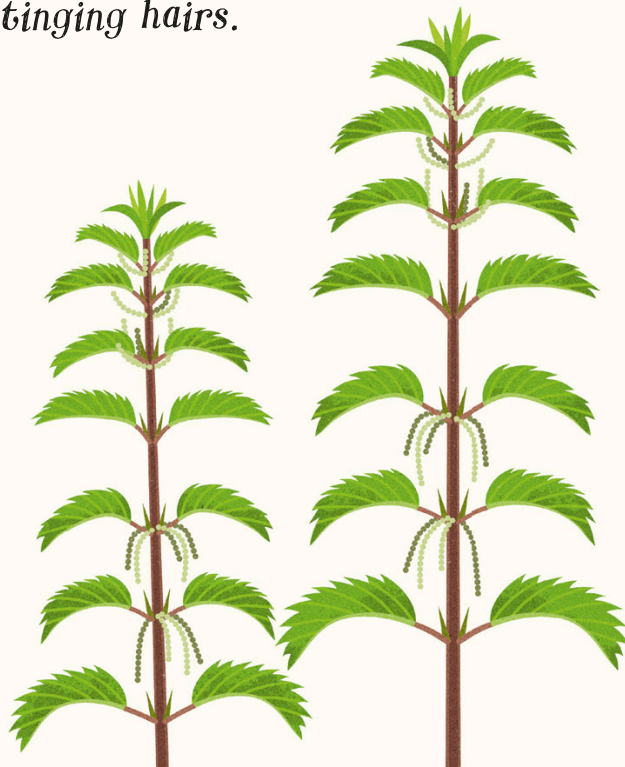
Nettle

Ow! Touch a stinging nettle and your skin goes red and itchy. Why is it so painful? Like many plants, its leaves are juicy, so it needs a weapon to stop being eaten. Stinging nettles are covered in many pointed hairs. If anything touches a hair, its tip snaps off. The broken edge is sharp as a needle, and squirts out chemicals that cause pain and itching.

New Zealand is home to a monster nettle twice as tall as an adult human. This tree nettle gives such a fierce sting that it can kill some animals. Some other sneaky plants have leaves that look very similar to nettles. They don't sting, but attackers still leave them alone just in case!

Stinging nettles provide food for many types of caterpillar.

The caterpillars avoid the stinging hairs.



Stinging nettle, Northern Africa,
Europe, and Asia